

Something that came to mind today. AI is not the biggest water consumer.

Posted by u/Putridlemons • • 0 points • 20 comments

I'm so tired of people being against AI due to "harming the environment" as if there aren't significantly larger water consumers that absolutely outnumber the amount of water AI consumes. When the world eventually ends, no one is gonna be blaming AI.

It takes about 5 gallons of water to produce one singular walnut.

The United States produces about 608 metric tons of walnuts annually, translating to about 73.5 million walnuts produced daily.

This means 367.5 million gallons of water are used daily, only for walnut production.

Google data centers such as google drive and gmail only accumulate about 550,000 gallons of water daily to cool down their system.

ChatGBT utilizes about 39 million gallons of water a day to cool down their data centers. Which is still ****9 times less**** than the water used for walnut production.

We don't fucking need walnuts, and we don't really need AI either, but walnuts are something that we certainly can live without that causes more harm to the earth's water supply over AI.

Same goes for coffee production. About 37 gallons per cup. Over 2 billion cups of coffee are consumed daily worldwide. That's 74 billion gallons of water used daily. Not even a scratch on what AI uses for cooling systems. The amount of water AI utilizes in a YEAR isn't as high as the amount of water used for coffee on a DAILY BASIS.

Comments

u/Fit-Elk1425 • 1 points • 2025-05-25 01:47 UTC

Its because of the presumption that novel industry and tech are unnecessary industries while any agricultural industries must be preserved no matter their enviromental cost.

u/NotAnAIOrAml • -1 points • 2025-05-12 18:10 UTC

You missed the essential point.

A walnut is a useful food item.

57 "reproduce this exactly" which morphs Chris Hemsworth into Amy Schumer is not.

Glad I could clear that up for you.

u/Putridlemons • 1 points • 2025-05-13 08:40 UTC

I think we can live without walnuts bro. Walnuts are not a necessity. I don't think the world would crumble without walnuts. It's the same for AI, but one of those two uses a lot more freshwater.

u/NotAnAIOrAml • 0 points • 2025-05-13 11:06 UTC

It's spooky-crazy that you equate food with AI slop. Good thing you don't make decisions for other people about either of them.

"No more walnuts for the world!", says PutridLemons.

Username checks out. Can't wait to see your list of acceptable food.

u/Putridlemons • 1 points • 2025-05-13 19:36 UTC

Neither of them are necessities, one just uses a lot more fresh water than the other (hint: it's the walnuts), which defeats the circulatory argument of wanting to get rid of AI due to water consumption.

Crazy to me that you call it "AI slop" as you generate shitty Star Wars prompts on ChatGBT.

u/NotAnAIOrAml • 0 points • 2025-05-13 19:39 UTC

>Crazy to me that you call it "AI slop" as you generate shitty Star Wars prompts on ChatGBT.

I think you're deluded, or maybe having a stroke. Don't know what this is supposed to mean.

You can't tell the difference in value between throwaway garbage and food. Not surprised. You must be very young.

u/Putridlemons • 1 points • 2025-05-13 19:51 UTC

"Don't know what this is supposed to mean."

That's alright, Grandpa. We'll figure it out together.

Most people who use the phrase "AI slop" are people who are against the usage of generative AI, which in your case would be contradictory, considering you also partake in the quote "AI slop." The most sloppiest of slop. Fuckin *Star Wars*. 🤖 🌹

I can tell the difference, but I also have the cognitive brain function to understand that the world will not be effected negatively if suddenly walnuts stopped being produced, same goes for AI. World hunger isn't going to make an increase over some damn walnuts dude, and no one is going to go insane over losing AI.

The only difference is that walnut production requires a significantly larger amount of water, whereas AI utilizes a much lower quantity, most of the water consumed being recycled water, unfiltered water, salt water, etc.

If the worlds problem with generative AI is "It's stealing our freshwater! The world is gonna go dry because of AI! You're harming the environment!" Then their concern for the environment is performative activism. If they cared about the overconsumption of freshwater, they would be more focused on nut production. Or even just other environmental factors. Littering, greenhouse gasses/fossil fuels/air pollution, the conservation of trees, utilizing solar energy, electric cars, recycling, etc.

When the world fuckin ends at some point, it won't be because of AI. I don't know how many times I have to explain this to you before you begin to comprehend it, so if you aren't able to get what I'm saying by now, I'll just leave this conversation here. There is no point in trying to explain logic to a brick wall.

u/NotAnAIOrAml

• 0 points
• 2025-05-13 20:24 UTC

tl;dr - If you can't say it in one sentence, it must be a long, convoluted, lame attempt to throw shade.

Pass.

u/Herr_Drosselmeyer • 2 points • 2025-05-12 10:10 UTC

Water being "used" is a weird metric anyways. It depends a lot on how it's used. Water used for cooling in power plants and data centers is usually only very lightly polluted, if at all and can be returned to the cycle with little to no issues.

Compare that to other industries like mining, steel, chemical production, paper mills, textiles etc., which can heavily pollute the water, making it unusable if not thoroughly treated.

u/HenryTudor7 • 2 points • 2025-05-12 03:00 UTC

When it comes to wasting resources, Bitcoin used more data processing than AI in 2024 (as far as I can tell), while not doing anything useful at all.

u/FireflyArc • 2 points • 2025-05-11 23:56 UTC

Oh I saw a guy who had m.i t sources for the environmental stuff. You think j it holds any water? No pun intended.

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2025-05-11 22:17 UTC

[removed]

u/ytman • -2 points • 2025-05-11 21:20 UTC

This is apples/oranges.

Where do you think the 5 gallons of water goes?

You've got so much flow of water in a year right? Do you divert it to industry or crops? Do you use it in a way where it gets contaminated and is no longer in our potable water supply.

Etc.

Think for one second.

u/DefendingAIArt-ModTeam • 3 points • 2025-05-12 00:45 UTC

This sub is not for inciting debate. Please move your comment to aiwars for that.

u/Amethystea • 2 points • 2025-05-12 00:03 UTC

Agriculture does pollute the water with fertilizers, animal waste runoff, and pesticides. It is often considered the #1 cause of water pollution globally.

u/ytman • 0 points • 2025-05-12 00:11 UTC

Care to qualify that so we can start talking apples to apples? Are we just talking contaminated water or toxic water? How far down the water cycle are you willing to go or are we just wasting time here?

There is a huge difference between brownsite contamination and agricultural contamination. Mine run off can be orders of magnitude more dangerous. Many forms of industrial waste is literally sequestered away so as to not contaminate aquifers, springs, and other sources of water.

Are there issues with water supply? Absolutely.

Do you actually care about the water supply?

u/Krunkbuster • 4 points • 2025-05-11 21:57 UTC

The point of the post is

1. AI is not the biggest usage of water
2. It doesn't matter anyways, because it's not voiding the water from existence.

And how would a data center contaminate water? From copper heat sinks leeching copper into the water? Or from the sovl being sucked out of the water

u/ytman • -1 points • 2025-05-11 22:02 UTC

The question was water use in general. I see often these kinds of whataboutisms in a lot of areas.

I was generally saying apply the water loss appropriately.

Water used in food production versus industry are apples/oranges.

u/MisterViperfish • 5 points • 2025-05-11 20:41 UTC

Water used for AI can also be reused within the same system. Their estimates often count the same water several times over.

u/Putridlemons • 3 points • 2025-05-11 23:36 UTC

Exactly. There are numerous AI programs and data centers that actually recycle and reuse the water they utilize for cooling.

u/Miiohau • 6 points • 2025-05-11 18:33 UTC

Also depending on how the AI water usage numbers are calculated they might be counting water “used” over and over in a closed cooling system or they are counting water used by the power plant powering the data center.

Cooling systems even non closed ones output warm water that could still be reused for other purposes, so all that “water” use is substantially different from agricultural water use.

Power plant usage can be lowered by new power technologies or relocating the data center with to a place with cleaner power (I can wait an additional 85.12 milliseconds for chatGPT to respond). It is theoretically possible to make even the most “water-intensive” power generation can be made water-efficient by turning it into a closed system. We just typically don’t because water used for power generation isn’t actually that significant (at least compared to agriculture).

Also both cooling systems and power generation water use typically care less about the quality of the water used. An example is you could in theory use salt water in a cooling system or power generation, while most plants would die if watered with salt water. There are of course exceptions like black water (used toilet water) due to the increased solids using black water in power generation system that turns water to steam can be problematic but plants (within certain tolerances) love black water due to the increased organic compounds.

Basically water use by AI is caused by it being efficient to use water while water use by agriculture is more intrinsic. Which makes both more and less important to cut water use by AI. More important because it is easier to reduce, less because it is easier to reduce.

u/Amethystea • 2 points • 2025-05-11 23:57 UTC

The water is assumed based on electricity usage and evaporative losses at thermoelectric power plants. It isn't the data center just using water like that and the numbers rely on assuming that the power comes from thermoelectric and non renewable sources.

u/Excellent-Berry-2331 • 4 points • 2025-05-11 17:44 UTC

If it was about heat, they could *maybe* talk

u/hipocampito435 • 2 points • 2025-05-11 17:05 UTC

I'd happily accept to dry the entirety of Earth's oceans just for an LLM to answer a single, vital question